

From PC to TV in 12 Steps

If you have a decently configured PC with good speakers and a DVD drive, converting it to serve as a media entertainment centre is a simple matter of installing a good TV tuner card and the appropriate software.

All you need to do is plug the TV tuner card, install the drivers and software, connect the cable to the card and scan for channels. You can also prioritise and name channels as you please. Of course, the installation and configuration does take a while, but nothing beats having a personal TV in your room!

1 As this project requires setting up both hardware and software, the first step consists opening the cabinet, finding a suitable free PCI slot and inserting the TV tuner card—in our case the Compro VideoMate TV Gold+. Once the card is attached, start the computer.

2 As soon as you start the computer, the operating system will display a message saying "Multimedia Controller Found".

If you view the device manager at this moment, you will find a number of devices marked with question marks or exclamations. You will be asked to insert the driver CD to continue installing the drivers—insert the CD provided by the manufacturer, and press Next.

3 Windows will try to search for the drivers from the CD-ROM drive, and then list all the suitable ones. If the list shows more than one, then choose the right one, according to the OS installed. Select the driver, and press Next again.

Windows may show a warning pop-up saying that the drivers are not digitally signed, this means that Microsoft hasn't approved the driver, but it's generally alright to go ahead and continue the driver installation. If you face a problem later, you can use system restore, and roll back

the drivers in Windows XP. When you press Next, the driver installation process begins. Once it's done, press Finish to complete installation.

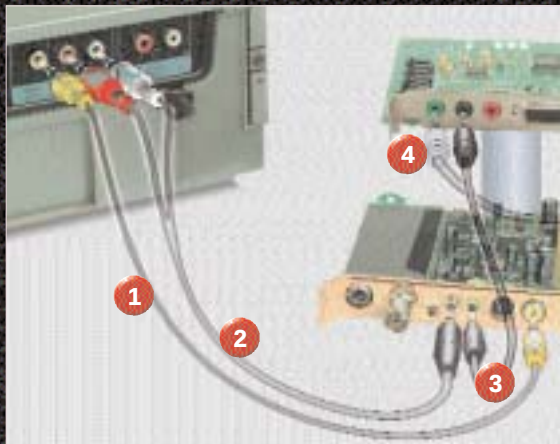
4 If you check the device manager, you'll see that due to the add-on drivers that are needed, the list of devices with question marks and exclamations has increased. Windows should remedy this automatically, but if it asks for the driver CD, repeat the previous step.

Once the process is completed, all the unknown devices will have vanished, and the list in 'Sound, Video and game controllers' will display the new set of hardware installed.

5 Now, we go back to the hardware level, to do the wiring properly. To capture TV signals, connect the TV cable to the tuner card.

To get a video signal via composite, connect the Audio Out of the Video player to the Audio In jack, and connect the composite out jack of the player to the Composite In of the tuner card.

If your card does not have Audio In, you need to connect the Audio Out of the video player to



Key to buttons



By clicking this button, you can change the video source from TV to S-Video, or Composite



The nail and hammer symbol opens the settings window, where by you change the different parameters.

3



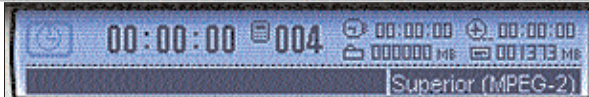
Click this button to take snapshots of your favourite TV moments

4



These panels represent the normal TV functionality, while in time-shifting mode. The same enables you to Pause/Resume Live TV signals.

5



In this screen, you can observe lots of useful information such as the compression format used currently, the size of the recording file, as well as the amount of time that can still be recorded with the current free space. Finally, in time-shifting mode, it shows two time intervals—one in the extreme top-right corner with the live signal timing, and the other in the centre showing the point where the user paused.